

Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment

Reforming research assessment: CoARA action plan Radboud University

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Prepared by Franke van der Molen
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1. Introduction

The universities of The Netherlands collectively decided to enter the Coalition for Advancing Research Assessment (CoARA) by signing the [Agreement on Reforming Research Assessment](#) (ARRA) in 2022. Daniël Wigboldus, president of the executive board of Radboud University, signed the agreement on behalf of Radboud University in November 2022. One of the obligations in ARRA is that participating organisations share with each other and with their communities how they are implementing the [Core Commitments](#) according to an action plan. This document is intended to fulfil this obligation, by describing the actions that Radboud University has taken and will take to reform its practices and principles of research assessment in the context of CoARA and other relevant initiatives and developments.¹

2. Context: existing frameworks and initiatives

Radboud University has been involved for a longer time in initiatives to improve research assessment. For instance, research assessment at the level of research institutes has been improved through the iterated review and revision of the national [Strategy Evaluation Protocol](#), which corresponds with the main principles of CoARA. The SEP notably corresponds with the first three commitments of CoARA that concern the recognition of diverse contributions to research, the importance of qualitative evaluation for which peer review is essential, and the responsible use of quantitative indicators and metrics.

Furthermore, the assessment of academics and support staff is currently under revision in the Recognition & Rewards (R&R) program of Radboud University (2023-2026), which is embedded in the national [Recognition and Rewards](#) program. R&R aims to better recognise and reward the diverse work of academics, to focus more on the quality of all types of academic work, and to devote greater attention to all areas in which university staff is active, including research, teaching, impact, patient care and leadership. Furthermore, it aims to realise a fundamental change in career perspectives for university staff and in behaviour and leadership with regards to the recognition and rewards system in academia. The Radboud [vision on recognition and rewards](#) serves as the foundation for the university's recognition and rewards program. The actions on reforming research assessment will be executed in consultation and collaboration with this program.

3. Main actions

By entering CoARA, Radboud University has bound itself to the core commitments. Appendix 1 provides a comprehensive overview of these commitments, and how these translate into actions at Radboud University. Several actions are already ongoing, for instance in the context of the R&R program. The following actions to reform research assessment are new:

1. Formulate principles for the responsible use of research metrics in the assessment of academics (milestone 1: 2025).
2. Develop and implement a framework, building on milestone 1, for qualitative research evaluation and responsible use of quantitative indicators in the context of assessing,

¹ These other initiatives and developments include the San Francisco Declaration on Research Assessment (DORA), the Open Science movement, the Strategy Evaluation Protocol (SEP) for research assessment in The Netherlands, and the Recognition and Rewards program of Dutch public research organizations.

hiring and promoting academics (milestone 2: development 2025-2026, implementation 2027). This framework will incorporate team science, i.e. the contributions of academics to team efforts and the assessment of teams as collectives.

3. Review existing criteria and processes, including in relation to the SEP, for the assessment of quality and impact of research at the level of research institutes. Inventory the demand for additional guidance and services, including research intelligence (milestone 3: 2025).
4. Develop additional guidance, support and/or services, focusing on research quality and societal impact, for research assessment at the level of research institutes (milestone 4: development 2026, implementation 2027). This may include guidance and support to both research institutes and assessment committees.

Communication

Progress and results of the actions will be periodically communicated in existing networks and consultations within Radboud University. Where relevant, communication on reforming research assessment will be embedded in the communication on the recognition and rewards program.

Evaluation

The actions will be finalized at the end of 2027. At that time, the first cycle of review and development of assessment criteria, tools and processes will be completed. An evaluation of the actions will take place after 2027.

4. Organization

- The actions on reforming research assessment will be coordinated and executed by a working group of 6-8 policy officers and managing directors, with participants from Radboud Services, faculties and research institutes.
- The actions will be executed under the guidance of the vice deans of research of Radboud University. The working group will report to the vice deans of research.
- The executive board is ultimately responsible for research quality assurance and establishes new or revised guidelines on research assessment. The vice deans of research give advice to the executive board on these matters.
- The working group will collaborate with, and ask for input and feedback from, existing academic communities and consultation platforms of Radboud University.
- Where relevant, the working group will consult and collaborate with the R&R project team and steering committee.

Appendix 1: Commitments and actions

CoARA Commitment	Current state of affairs at Radboud University	Actions + milestones
Recognise the diversity of contributions to, and careers in, research in accordance with the needs and nature of the research	This recognition of diversity lies at the core of the Radboud Recognition and Rewards program and is addressed, among other things, in the project Development Paths that is part of this program.	The R&R-project on development paths is ongoing, deadline 2024.
Abandon inappropriate uses in research assessment of journal- and publication-based metrics, in particular inappropriate uses of Journal Impact Factor (JIF) and h-index	This principle is already implemented in research assessment at the level of research institutes (SEP). Radboud University currently has no general guidelines for the application of journal- and publication-based metrics in research assessment at the level of individual academics.	• Milestone 1: Formulate principles for responsible use of metrics in the assessment of academics.
Base research assessment primarily on qualitative evaluation for which peer review is central, supported by responsible use of quantitative indicators	This principle is already implemented in research assessment at the level of research institutes (SEP). In the assessment of individual academics, the application of more qualitative assessment approaches may be further supported and strengthened.	• Review assessment practices and criteria at the level of individual academics. This is an ongoing action in the R&R program / development paths project. • Milestone 2: develop a framework for qualitative evaluation and responsible use of quantitative indicators and metrics in the context of assessing, hiring and promoting academics. This framework will incorporate the assessment of team science.
Avoid the use of rankings of research organisations in research assessment	Radboud University has a critical and nuanced approach towards international rankings and works together with other Dutch universities in furthering the responsible use of rankings. Radboud University does not use international rankings in its assessment of research.	Engage in further actions, together with other Dutch Universities, aimed towards the responsible application of and communication on rankings.
Commit resources to reforming research assessment as is needed to achieve the organisational changes committed to.	Radboud University has allocated resources for the execution of the Recognition & Rewards and Open Science programs.	The members of the working group will contribute on an in kind basis. The working group will make use of existing networks and consultation structures.

Review and develop research assessment criteria, tools and processes	For research assessment at the level of research institutes, assessment criteria, tools and processes are already in place but may be further improved. Criteria, tools and processes for the assessment of individual academics may be further developed and applied. This is an objective of the R&R program.	• Milestone 3: Review existing criteria and processes for the assessment of quality and impact of research at the level of research institutes. Inventory the demand for additional guidance and services, including research intelligence. • Milestone 4: Develop additional guidance, support and/or services, focusing on research quality and societal impact, at the level of research institutes. • See also milestones 1 and 2.
Raise awareness of research assessment reform and provide transparent communication, guidance, and training on assessment criteria and processes as well as their use.	Raising awareness within the organization is an objective of the communication strategy of the R&R program.	Training, guidance and support to assessment panels, committees, and juries will be included, where applicable, in the implementation phases of milestones 2 and 4.
Exchange practices and experiences to enable mutual learning within and beyond the Coalition.	The Dutch universities collaborate and exchange practices and experiences in various ways, including the national Recognition & Rewards program and collaboration on research quality assurance.	Radboud University will continue to collaborate in the context of UNL, the national Recognition & Rewards program, and possibly a CoARA national chapter.
Communicate progress made on adherence to the principles and implementation of the Commitments.		Progress updates will be communicated through existing networks and consultations and, where relevant, as part of the R&R communication strategy.
Evaluate practices, criteria and tools based on solid evidence and the state-of-the-art in research on research, and make data openly available for evidence gathering and research		The cycle of review and development of assessment criteria, tools and processes will be completed by the end of 2027. An evaluation is expected to take place subsequently, in 2028.